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ANALYSIS OF FLYING OBJECT INCIDENTS IN THE U.S.

Air Intelligence Division Study No. 203  
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Directorate of Intelligence and Office of Naval Intelligence

DISTRIBUTION "C"

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## APPENDIX "C"

### SELECTED REPORTS OF FLYING OBJECT INCIDENTS

1. A NUMBER of reports on unidentified flying objects come from observers who, because of their technical background and experience do not appear to be influenced by unfounded sensationalism nor inclined to report explainable phenomena as new types of airborne devices. Some of the details of their reports are presented in this appendix, along with those from possibly less reliable sources who have reported evidence which is of such a nature that it cannot be entirely ignored.

2. DESCRIPTIONS OF significant incidents, arranged chronologically, follow:

a. During April 1947, two employees of the Weather Bureau Station at Richmond, Virginia reported seeing a strange metallic disk on three occasions through the theodolite while making PIBAL observations. One observation was at 15,000 feet when a disk was followed for 15 seconds. The disk appeared metallic, shaped something like an ellipse with a flat bottom and a round top. It appeared below the balloon and was much larger in size. The disk appeared to be moving rather rapidly, although it was impossible to estimate its speed. The other observations were made at 27,000 feet in like manner.

b. The following month, ~~James H. Doolittle~~ a field engineer for Radio Corporation of America, reported a disk flying near his home in Oklahoma City, Oklahoma. The object was thought to be at an altitude between 10,000 feet and 18,000 feet, and was moving toward the north at a high rate of speed, leaving no trailing effects.

c. While flying at 10,000 feet on a course of 300 degrees, 30 miles northwest of Lake Meade, Nevada, an Air Force Lieutenant reported seeing five or six white circular objects in close formation and traveling at an estimated speed of 285 miles per hour. This sighting occurred on 28 June 1947.

d. The following day a party of three, two of them scientists, were motoring along Highway 17 toward the White Sand, New Mexico, V-2 firing grounds and reported seeing a large disk or sphere moving horizontally at a high speed and an estimated altitude of 10,000 feet. It was of uniform shape and had no protruding surfaces such as wings. The object was in sight for about 60 seconds before it disappeared to the northeast. The three observers agreed on the details of the sighting except that one thought he had seen vapor trails.

e. On 7 July 1947, five Portland, Oregon police officers reported varying numbers of disks flying over different parts of the city. All observations were made within a minute or two of 1305 hours.

f. On the same day, ~~William G. Brundage~~ of Phoenix, Arizona allegedly saw a disk circling his locality during sunset and took two photographs. The resulting pictures (page 9) show a disk-like object with a round front and a square tail in plan form. These photographs have been examined by experts who state they are true photographic images and do not appear to be imperfection in the emulsion or imperfections in the lens. (See Figs. 1, 2, 3 and 4.)

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g. On 10 July 1947, Mr. [REDACTED] a Pan-American Airways mechanic reported a circular object flying at high velocity, paralleling the earth's surface and leaving a trail which appeared as a "burning up" of the cloud formation. The sighting occurred near Harmon Field, Newfoundland. Two other persons also saw the trail which remained in the sky for about an hour and was photographed by another PAA employee. The resulting photographs support Mr. Woodruff's observation as far as the sky cleavage is concerned. (See Figs. 5 and 6.)

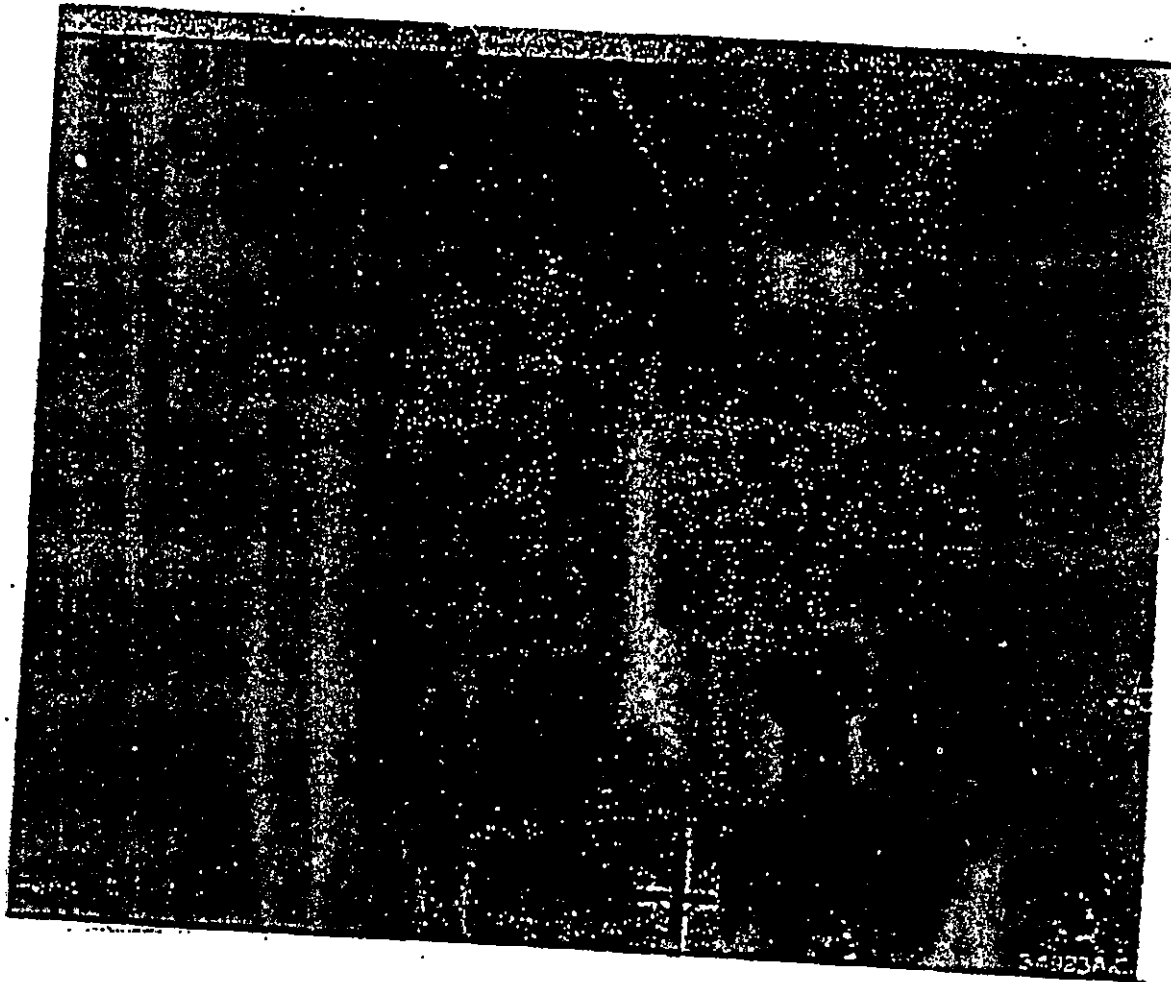


Fig. 5

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Fig. 6

h. On 29 July 1947, ~~██████████~~ while flying near Tacoma, Washington, reported a formation of flying objects. His sketch of their shape corresponds closely to that shown in the photographs made by Mr. ~~██████████~~. On the same day, two U. S. Air Force pilots at Hamilton Field reported two flying disks trailing a P-80, following it toward Oakland, California.

i. On 4 August 1947, the pilot and co-pilot of a DC-3, flying for one Al Jones, near Bethel, Alaska, reported a flying disk larger than their aircraft. This disk crossed their path at about 1,000 feet and they turned to give chase. The DC-3 was flying at 170 mph, but the disk flew out of sight in four minutes.

j. On 12 November 1947, two flying disks trailing jet-like streams of fire were reportedly sighted from the bridge of the tanker Ticonderoga, according to the second officer. The Ticonderoga was 20 miles off the Oregon shore. This officer said the disks were in sight 45 seconds, moving at a speed estimated at 700-900 mph, curving in a long, low arc.

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k. On 7 January 1948, a National Guard pilot was killed while attempting to chase an unidentified object up to 30,000 feet. While it is presumed that this pilot suffered anoxia, resulting in his crash, his last message to the tower was, "It appears to be metallic object....of tremendous size....directly ahead and slightly above....I am trying to close for a better look."

l. On 5 April 1948, three trained balloon observers from the Geophysics Laboratory Section, Watson Laboratories, N.J. reported seeing a round, indistinct object in the vicinity of Holloman Air Force Base, New Mexico. It was very high and fast, and appeared to execute violent maneuvers at high speed. The object was under observation for approximately 30 seconds and disappeared suddenly.

m. A yellow or light colored sphere, 25 to 40 feet in diameter was reported by Lt. Comdr. Marcus L. Lowe, USN, just south of Anacostia Naval Air Station, D.C., while he was flying on 30 April 1948. It was moving at a speed of approximately 100 miles per hour at an altitude of about 4,500 feet. Although winds aloft were from the north-northwest, its course was to the north.

n. On 1 July 1948, twelve disks were reported over the Rapid City Air Base by Major Hammer. These disks were oval-shaped, about 100 feet long, flying at a speed estimated to be in excess of 500 mph. Descending from 10,000 feet, these disks made a 30-degree to 40-degree climbing turn accelerating very rapidly until out of sight.

o. On 17 July 1948, a report from Kirtland Air Force Base describes a sighting in the vicinity of San Acacia, New Mexico, of seven unidentified objects flying in a "V" formation at an estimated height of 20,000 feet above the terrain. The formation varied from "V" to "L" to circle after passing the zenith. Flashes from the objects were observed after passing 30 degrees beyond the zenith but there was no smoke or vapor trail. If the reported altitude is correct the speed was estimated at 1,500 miles per hour, according to the report.

p. Other sightings of lights and trails, rather than disks, have been reported, viz:

(1) On 12 September 1947, the pilot and co-pilot of a Pan American aircraft, en route from Midway to Honolulu, saw a blue-white light approaching, changing to twin reddish glows upon withdrawal. The pilot estimated the speed of the light at about 1,000 knots.

(2) On 15 June 1948, Mr. [redacted] territory manager for the B.F. Goodrich Company, observed a reddish glow with a jet exhaust in the vicinity of Miles City, Montana. This glowing light made no sound, traveled about twice the speed of a conventional aircraft and flew from north to south several times in a wide arc, finally disappearing over the horizon.

q. During the early morning of 25 July 1948, two Eastern Airlines pilots reported having seen a huge flying craft similar to a V-2 pass their aircraft in flight. (See Figs. 7 and 8.) The attached drawings made by these two observers very closely resemble a flying object reported to have been seen on 20 July 1948, by [redacted], chief investigator of Court of Damage Inquiry, and his daughter at Arnhem, Netherlands. This object appeared to be a wingless aircraft having two decks. The craft, sighted four times through scattered clouds and unlimited visibility, was traveling at high speed at a high altitude. A sound similar to that made by a V-2 was reported.

r. An object, similar in shape to the one in the preceding incident was reported by an experienced American newspaper reporter about 25 kilometers northeast of Moscow on 3 August 1948. A Russian acquaintance identified it as a rigid airship but the reporter disagrees because it flew at a high, but not excessive speed.

s. On 1 October 1948 at approximately 2030 hours the pilot of a F-51 aircraft, 2nd Lt. George F. Gorman (North Dakota Air National Guard), flying near Fargo, North Dakota, sighted an intermittent white light about 3,000 feet below his 4,500 feet cruising altitude. The pilot pursued the light which appeared to then take evasive tactics. The object or light out-turned, out-speeded, and out-climbed the F-51 in every instance during the attempt to intercept. The pilot lost contact 27

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minutes after the initial sighting. The same light was observed by three other witnesses from the ground: Mr. [REDACTED], Air Traffic Controller, Mr. [REDACTED] Assistant Traffic Controller, and Dr. [REDACTED], Oculist. A comparison of all testimony revealed that one object was sighted and that it consisted only of a small round ball of clear white light with no apparent shape attached. It was about 6 to 8 inches in diameter. At times it traveled faster than the F-51 and performed maneuvers in an evasive manner. When first sighted the ball of light was traveling at an estimated 250 miles per hour. Under this condition, the light was not continuous but blinked off and on. At high performance the white light was continuous. Subsequent investigation eliminated the possibility that this incident may have been another aircraft or a meteorological balloon.

1. On 18 November 1948 at approximately 2145 hours, three reserve pilots, 2nd Lt. Kanwood W. Jackson, 2nd Lt. Glen L. Stalker, and 2nd Lt. Henry G. Combs, flying near Andrews Field, Maryland, encountered an unidentified flying object. When first sighted, it appeared to be lighted and flying at about 1,700 feet. Three or four passes were made in an attempt to identify it. The pilot of the aircraft stated that while diving his aircraft at approximately 240 miles per hour, the object would climb vertically and then would drop below the aircraft from behind and continue to circle. On the last pass, the landing light was switched on and momentarily a dull gray glow from the object was observed. Lt. Combs stated he maintained contact for about ten minutes with the object flying between the lights of Washington, D. C. and his aircraft. All that could be observed was an oblong ball with one light, no wings and no exhaust flame. It finally made a very tight turn and headed toward the east coast at an estimated 500 to 600 miles per hour. At the same time Staff Sergeant John J. Kushner observed from the ground an unusual object in the air over Andrews Field. He stated that it was not very high and that it did not look like an aircraft.

3. REPORTS OF radar intercepts point to unusual air activity which may be related to flying objects.

a. On 1 July 1947, a GCA radar at Hokkaido, Japan picked up an unidentified target at 16 miles, with a speed in excess of 500 mph. This target split into two targets, each estimated to be larger than a P-51.

b. On 16 September 1947, an MEW radar at Fukuoka, Japan, picked up a target at 89 miles and trailed it to 19 miles, where it faded. Speed was 840-900 mph. The speed measurement, made by a good crew through a 70-mile track, is believed accurate.

4. Investigations conducted by Headquarters, Air Materiel Command, have definitely established the identification of 18 of approximately 210 so-called flying saucers which have been reported. Approximately nine per cent of the total number of incidents are, therefore, eliminated from further specific consideration. Among those incidents positively explained, three were hoaxes, two were from unreliable witnesses. In the remaining 13 eliminated incidents, objects were actually seen but investigation has shown that they were celestial bodies or phenomena, meteorological and carnival balloons, and airborne cosmic ray experimental equipment. The following examples are presented for comparison of the information reported by witnesses and true identification of the object involved:

a. On 22 July 1948, Captain Henry Glover (Ordnance Reserve) and his wife observed at Van Nuys, California, an object which they were unable to positively identify. Object at first appeared to be round and looked like a weather balloon at about 2,000 feet but there was no characteristic bobbing. The wind was blowing on the ground but the object was quite steady. During the time it was under observation, about an hour, it traveled through a vertical arc of about twenty-five (25) degrees or more. The observer concluded that it was not a celestial body. It has a bluish luminescence and as the sun set, the object's color gradually changed to orange at dusk and ceased to be illuminated almost instantaneously. The outline was clear and the air was clear with visibility unlimited. The object traveled from the east to the west.

This object was determined by investigation to have been a balloon carrying cosmic ray equipment.

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b. On 19 August 1948, at approximately 1050 hours an unidentified flying object was visible from the ground at Godman Air Force Base, Kentucky. This object was estimated to be at about 30,000 to 40,000 feet altitude, spherical in shape, bright silver color and gave a bright reflection from the sun. An F-51 was dispatched from Standiford Air Force Base, Kentucky, to observe the object. During observation from the ground, there was no change in the elevation of the object and it seemed to be moving southwest from Godman Air Force Base. The F-51 which was flying over Godman AFB at an altitude of 30,000 to 35,000 feet reported that it was unable to locate the object although it was still visible from the ground with the naked eye. Azimuth and elevation readings were taken by theodolite every minute and the path of the object was charted.

The object was determined to be the planet Venus by Mr. Moore, the head astronomer at the University of Louisville, Louisville, Kentucky. It is believed that earlier incidents at Godman Field (reference paragraph 2k, page 12, Appendix "C") may also have been observations of the planet Venus.

5. AMONG THOSE incidents still not positively explained, reported observations differ to some extent, but three general categories of sightings emerge -- the flying disk, the ball of fire and the large jet rocket. Interesting observations that were noted are:

a. Most of the objects are a thin disk, round on top and flat on the bottom. The front half of the disk is often circular, sweeping back to a square tail across the full width.

b. A high rate of climb as well as the apparent ability to remain motionless or hover for a considerable length of time is indicated.

c. Reported sizes have varied from that of a 25-cent piece to 250 feet in diameter, and from the size of a pursuit plane to the bulk of six B-29 airplanes.

d. Speeds have been estimated throughout the entire range from very slow or hovering to supersonic.

e. Sounds and visual trails are not normally associated with the sightings.

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